



management does not dictate pitch preparation. Nonetheless, the plan visibly backfired, with Ashwin and Jadeja performing below par in Pune, a pivotal match in the series.

Interestingly, this New Zealand series marked Ashwin's second-poorest Test outing at

home, with a bowling average of 41.22 runs per wicket. His only worse home series was against England in 2012-13, when he averaged 52.64 runs per wicket—India's last home Test series loss.

India appeared ensnared by its

own spin trap, inviting criticism from former players, including Harbhajan Singh. Taking to social media, Harbhajan remarked, "Earlier generations' batsmen never played on these kinds of tracks. These tracks are prepared for 2-3 day Test matches. You don't need Murali